were introducing “green belts” around cities, where new building was almost entirely banned. Green belts were designed to stop cities from spreading and merging with other towns.

Modern definitions of urban sprawl vary, but it generally has negative overtones. At its most extreme, it has created megacities—defined by the United Nations as cities of more than 10 million people. Examples of such megacities include Tokyo-Yokohama (38 million), Jakarta (30 million), and Delhi (25 million).

“The old city is submerged in a far-flung, multicentered, mostly low-density, highly heterogeneous urban region.”

Robert Bruegmann

Ecological upset

Some researchers claim urban sprawl is the most serious threat to biodiversity from any human activity. The new suburbs house relatively few people, yet require extensive and disproportionate levels of infrastructure, such as power and water supplies and transportation networks. As cities swell, valuable farmland is covered in concrete and natural habitats are disrupted or lost entirely. Sprawl can also disturb local fauna and flora through the introduction of pets and invasive plants that threaten indigenous species. Limited public transportation in low density areas also means that suburban populations tend to be multiple car owners, which adds to the levels of air pollution in cities—as do the wood- and coal-burning stoves of the poor in outlying shanty towns.

The area of the world currently covered in urban development is one-and-a-half times the size of France. Mexico City has expanded more than any other city in the West. Spreading far beyond its official boundaries to become the home of more than 21 million people, it has also grown disproportionately: in 1970–2000, the surface area of the city grew 1.5